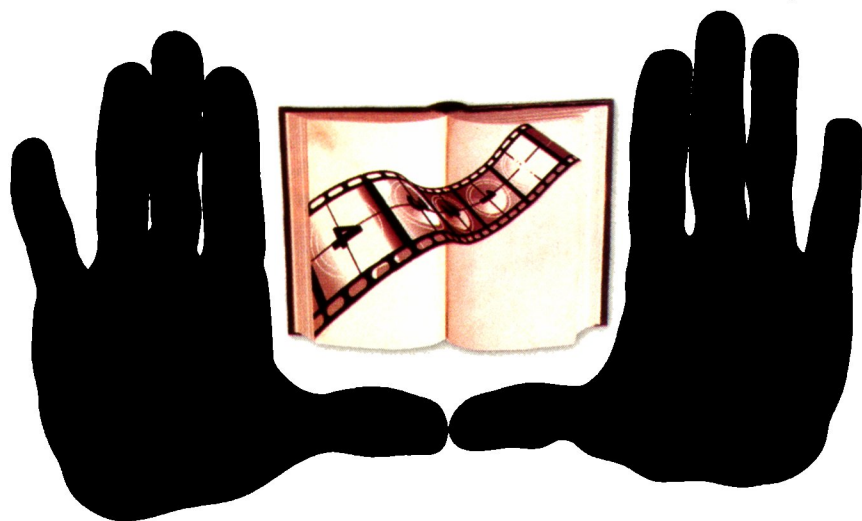




Moving Picture

Terrors of communalism get a cinematic treatment in Tabish Khair's new novel that taps the histories of love and hatred



FILMING: A LOVE STORY
by TABISH KHAIR
Picador
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 399

■ By Brinda Bose

Reviewing an Eng Lit teacher's novel that explores 20th-century India's political, cultural and emotional histories of communalism through the fascination of (and for) Indian cinema, could I have had anything but high expectations? Tabish Khair—novelist, poet, professor and lit-critic—rises delightfully to the occasion with a multi-narrative that intermixes straightforward, low-key story-telling, flashbacks, dream sequences and action shots with admirable elan, unfurling a tale in print that mimics—both in content and in style—the flaming allure of the Indian “bioscope”.

Khair is surely inspired by both Indian cinema and Indian literature.

The book, ascribed to the memory of Saadat Hasan Manto and dedicated to Khushwant Singh, acknowledges his intellectual debts to two writers who immortalised Partition on paper. But it also recalls some of the quiet elegance of *The Shadow Lines*, Amitav Ghosh's 1988 novel about the fallout of Partition. The telling of stories in different voices, the constant looping back in time, a young scholar's search for truth in matching and unmatching tales, and revelations at the end that make some of the jigsaw puzzle pieces fit enough to make the narrative coherent while remaining at best translucent—these are effects well-imbibed and trans-created in *Filming: A Love Story*.

Those who love and revel in Indian cinema will undoubtedly enjoy Khair's book most, for its cinematic take on Indian people and their histories of love and hatred in equal passion lifts this literary-filmic feast to hitherto unattained heights of nostalgic association. *Filming: A Love Story* is a novel about

cinema, both its making and its mesmerising of all those who fall under its spell. But it is equally about the terrors of communalism that creep at a petty pace into the lives of mixed communities in middle-class India, which co-exist oblivious of that threat until the poison begins to take effect. Then the picture of a happy heterogeneity, ironically like a celluloid fantasy, crumbles and disappears overnight, leaving in its wake a bewildered people whose psyche is fatally bruised.

Khair's novel, though it stretches across much of the 20th century and into the present, is essentially a tribute to the tent-theatre days of Indian cinema and skirts what we know today as Bollywood. It is the story of Harihar, a cinema-struck, penniless clerk who woos a young Durga by selling her his inextinguishable dream of making it rich by screening two-reel films in temporary tents across rural India. They travel through villages with their young son Ashok in search of an elusive fortune until they encounter a rich land-owning family whose *chhote thakur* is as fascinated by celluloid as Harihar, and a deal is struck, by which Harihar barter Ashok into the childless family for a chance to set up his own directorial venture in Bombay.

Filming: A Love Story is narrated by voices as diverse as that of an aged scriptwriter's who has settled in Copenhagen with his wife, a young intrepid scholar who sniffs a story to his door and stays all night at his apartment drinking in his tale along with whisky, interspersed with a mysterious voice-over by a beautiful 30-something lady-doctor who recalls family stories inherited from her father, who boasted a dual heritage, one poor and the other land-owning. The tales recorded in the young scholar's moleskin notebook, from Copenhagen to rural Indian Phansa, are intertwined in the most riveting ways. The picture that emerges may sear your soul, much like your all-time favourite Hindi film. ■

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